Asper Business Case Competition 2027

Team Briefing: Format, Rules and Deliverables

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HSBI

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Overview

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What is the ABCC?

Asper Business Case Competition (ABCC)

A five-day, graduate-level business case competition hosted by the I. H. Asper School of Business, University of Manitoba, in Winnipeg, Canada. The 2027 edition (February 15–20) is the **fifth annual** competition.

- Hosted at the **Drake Centre**, 181 Freedman Crescent, University of Manitoba campus
- Teams from top Canadian business schools – and, since 2026, international teams
- 2026 field: 9 graduate teams, incl. HEC Montréal, DeGroote, Beedie, Babeș-Bolyai (Romania)

Why It Matters for Us

- First-hand experience with the **North American case method** under time pressure
- Benchmarking against strong Canadian MBA/graduate teams – the 2025 field included Ivey, John Molson, HEC Montréal, Telfer, DeGroote, Beedie, Levene, Memorial and Asper
- In 2026, the international newcomer Babeș-Bolyai University **won** the competition – international teams can absolutely compete for the title
- Rich social program: team-bonding events, networking with judges from industry, gala dinner with awards

Scale of the event (2026)

35 participants, 9 faculty advisors, 50 industry judges, 52 volunteers.

Team Composition and Eligibility

- Teams consist of **four students**; all four present in every round
- Open to graduate-level students (full-time, part-time, executive MBA, and Masters-level students of other management programs)
- Each team travels with a **faculty advisor / coach** (that is me)
- Maximum of four laptops per team; **no cellphones or smartwatches** during case preparation and presentations

Golden rule

Every team member must speak in every presentation and discussion round; judging uses the official 7-category team rubric.

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The 2027 Competition Week (Official Schedule)

Date	Programme	Round
Mon Feb 15	Team arrival (registration, division draw)	–
Tue Feb 16	Opening ceremonies; **prepared case** presentations	1
Wed Feb 17	**Boardroom case**: 4 h prep + presentations	2
Thu Feb 18	Excursion day	–
Fri Feb 19*	**10-hour case**: preparation	3
Sat Feb 20	10-hour case presentations, **finals**, awards dinner	3 + final

- Published on the official page (checked 31 Oct 2026); times follow later. *Printed as "Feb 22" – almost certainly a typo
- New for 2027: the third round becomes a **10-hour case** instead of the 3-hour traditional case (to be confirmed) – and a rest day before it

Three Rounds, Three Different Styles

Round	Prep time	Format	Weight
1: Prepared case	ca. 2 weeks (before travel)	25 min + 15 min Q&A	25 %
2: Boardroom case	short (4 h in 2026)	3 min + 22 min discussion	30 %
3: 10-hour case	**10 h** (2026: 3 h)	20 min + 10 min Q&A	45 %

- Escalating difficulty and point value across the three rounds
- Top 3 teams advance to a **final round** in front of a new judge panel
- Ties broken by the highest third-round (traditional) score

Round 1: The Prepared Case

Format

25-minute presentation + 15-minute Q&A. Unlimited slides and exhibits. Time warnings at 5 minutes (yellow) and 1 minute (red).

- Case is released **weeks before the competition** – worked on at home
- A real client: in 2026 this was **Jazz Winnipeg** (pitch a radical new operational idea)
- All resources may be used – **except** contacting employees of the case sponsor
- The coach **may** give input on this case (unlike rounds 2 and 3)
- Slide deck must be **submitted before the deadline** – late submissions are placed at the bottom of the pool

Round 2: The Boardroom Case

Format

Seated boardroom setting: 3-minute uninterrupted recommendation, then 22 minutes of open discussion with the judges (in 2026: four judges plus a company representative).

- Short preparation window on site (4 hours in 2025 and 2026)
- Protected 3 minutes: **one summary slide only** – appendices are blocked; red card at 1 minute
- Appendices unlocked for the 22-minute discussion (yellow/red cards at 5/1 minutes)
- Judges receive a **one-page black-and-white brief** in advance; deck + brief handed in on a provided USB stick
- Seated delivery via wireless keyboard/mouse; **no coach contact** after case release
- 2026 client: Coal & Canary – elevate the brand from premium to luxury

Round 3: Traditional Case → 10-Hour Case

Format

Classic case-competition style: 20-minute presentation + 10-minute Q&A. Time warnings at 5 minutes (yellow) and 1 minute (red).

- 2027: listed as a **10-hour case** – prep on Friday, presentation on Saturday (2025/2026: 3 hours, same day). Details to be confirmed
- Highest weight of all rounds: **45 %** of the total score – and the deck the finalists re-present
- One laptop per student; no cellphones or smartwatches
- **No coach contact** after case release
- 2026 client: Access Credit Union – service innovations to engage young customers

The Final Round

- The **top 3 teams** present again before a fresh judge panel
- 20-minute presentation + 15-minute Q&A
- Slide decks **cannot be modified** for the final
- Faculty advisors may not communicate with their team until after the presentation
- Winners announced at the **awards dinner** (2027: Sat Feb 20)

2026 podium

1. Babeș-Bolyai University (Romania) 2. DeGroote School of Business 3. HEC Montréal

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What We Must Hand In Before the Competition

1. **Registration** of the school/team with the organizers (contact: aspercasecomps@umanitoba.ca – Judith Jayasuriya, Steven Harrison)
2. **Team roster**: four students + faculty advisor, with bios/photos as requested by the organizers
3. **Prepared-case slide deck** (Round 1): **.pptx only**, submitted by e-mail, file named "[Team Name] Prepared Case" – 2027 expected: release ∼Feb 1, due ∼Feb 15 (2025: 10:00 CT, arrival day); we submit by Sat Feb 13. Late = bottom of the pool
4. Any **forms and waivers** sent by the organizing committee after registration
5. Optional but smart: **prebuilt slide template** for the on-site rounds (explicitly allowed; build it in advance)

Note

2027 day plan published; times, deadlines and 10-hour case details follow after registration – tracked in the repository.

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Core Rules Across All Rounds

- Competition language: **English**; presentations must be **PowerPoint (.pptx)** – no Prezi etc.
- All four team members must speak in every round (not necessarily during the protected 3 minutes of the boardroom pitch)
- One laptop per student; no cellphones or smartwatches during prep and presentation
- No contact with the coach after release of the boardroom and the third-round (10-hour) case; on-site decks are collected on a provided USB stick at fixed pickup times
- Time warnings: yellow card at 5 minutes, red card at 1 minute; **late arrival = no extra time**
- Slide clickers are provided; volunteers monitor rule compliance

Fair Play, Anonymity and Allowed Tools

Disqualification risks

Revealing your **school of origin** to a judge at any point, or any coach communication during a presentation or Q&A, leads to **disqualification**. Teams compete under neutral letters (division draw at registration).

- **Internet use is allowed** during prep – including university databases and **Generative AI**
- Prebuilt **own** slide templates are permitted (built outside prep time); no third-party templates for the prepared case
- Never contact employees of a case sponsor; cases are confidential – no sharing or reproducing
- Dress code: **business professional** throughout competition days

Scoring and Tie-Breaking

Round	Weight
Prepared case	25 %
Boardroom case	30 %
Traditional / 10-hour case	45 %

- Rubric-based evaluation by panels of industry judges
- Ties resolved by highest third-round score, then by performance in the weighted rounds and individual rubric categories
- Strategic implication: **the on-site rounds decide the competition** (75 % combined) – 4 h of speed and 10 h of depth; our training covers both

The Judging Rubric (Official, 2025 Event Guide)

Category	Weight
Implementation & resources	2.5×
Analysis	2.0×
Recommendation	2.0×
Communicating effectively	1.0×
Framing the problem	1.0×
Impact	1.0×
Measurement, risks & mitigation	1.0×

Training implication

Implementation & resources carries the highest weight (2.5×): every recommendation needs a concrete path – steps, owners, timeline, resources, and financials – not just a good idea.

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Playing to Our Strengths

Background	Natural lead role	Typical ownership
Finance	CFO of the team	Financials, valuation, sensitivity
Innovation	Creative lead	Idea generation, differentiation
Computer Science	Analytics/tech lead	Data, feasibility, digital angle
General Business	Strategist & integrator	Framing, structure, storyline

- Roles are **leads**, not silos – everyone masters the full storyline
- Rotating "presenter 1" role in practice so all four are strong openers

Preparation Roadmap (Details in the Prep Plan)

1. **Foundations** – case method, core frameworks, business math drills
2. **Skill building** – role-specific deep dives, slide craft, storylining
3. **Simulation** – timed mock cases: 4 h boardroom, 3 h speed runs, and full 10-hour days
4. **Prepared case sprint** – structured 2-week sprint once Case 1 is released
5. **Final polish** – Q&A gauntlet, dress rehearsals, kit check

Guiding principle

Train hardest for what weighs most: the on-site cases under competition-identical time limits and device rules.

Sources and Further Information

- Official page: `https://umanitoba.ca/asper/asper-business-case-competition`
- ABCC 2025 Event Guide (rules, rubric, schedule): `https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2025-01/abcc25-eventguide.pdf`
- Past case PDFs 2023–2026 (all eleven cases): mirrored in `01-competition/past-case-pdfs/` of our repository
- 2026 recap: `https://umtoday.ca/stories/forging-worldwide-relationships-2026-asper-business-case-competition`
- Instagram: @Asper_BCC Contact: aspercasecomps@umanitoba.ca

Status of information

Rules and rubric follow the official 2025 Event Guide and the 2027 website (schedule checked 31 Oct 2026); clients from 2025/2026. Times and deadlines are TBA – re-verify after registration.